in their assembly areas. His last words were, “Don’t worry, sir, despite their superiority the Rajputs won’t let you down. If you do get back, see to it that those who got us into this mess get their due.”’

THE VIEW FROM THAGLA

Over the past twenty days, the Chinese commanders had watched from their position on the Thagla Ridge as India’s 7 Infantry Brigade moved into the Nam Ka Chu Valley (the Chinese called it the Kejie Lang region), one battalion following the other and deploying along the length of the river. Not only was this reducing the fighting capability of these troops, but the Indian commander, by getting into the narrow valley, was effectively taking out of the equation the one factor that could turn the tide against the Chinese—the Indian Air Force. Any aircraft in support of the ground troops, even if it could make the turn west from the confluence of the Nam Ka Chu and the Nyamjang Chu, would be vulnerable even to small arms fire, for it would have to fly laterally across and below the Chinese positions.

Accordingly, the Chinese anti-aircraft detachments in support of Regiments 154, 155, 157, 31 and 32 who were poised for the attack across the Nam Ka Chu were positioned on the Thagla Ridge to take on any Indian air strikes which would perforce have to approach through the Nyamjang Chu valley. This left the Chinese with the 308 Artillery Regiment and the 136 Engineer Regiment in support of the five regiments, a total strength in excess of 10,000 men.

On 11 June 1962, after the ‘push and shove’ incident at Khenzemane, the Central Military Commission (CMC) had set up the Zang Zi 419 (Tibet Force 419) or the Forward HQ of the Tibet Military Command. At the time 31 and 32 Regiments were part of the 11 Infantry Division, but were subsequently shifted to the Tawang sector. Zang Zi 419 was equivalent to a full-strength Indian division, while each ‘regiment’ in the Chinese army was equal to an Indian brigade. Zang Zi 419 was under the charge of General Ching Hi, a veteran of the Korea War.

From the reports coming in from various Chinese observation posts, it was obvious that the Indian troops were deploying in a scattered form around company or reinforced company-sized units. The defences were mainly bunkers constructed from stone, wood and soil with barbed wire entanglements, abates, bamboo slips and land mines presumably guarding the approaches. The quality of the bunkers was reported as being inferior,